

POLICY SUBMISSION: ENHANCING REAL-WORLD STUDENT READINESS

Apr 24, 2026

I. Executive Summary

This submission outlines a strategic initiative to advance real-world decision-making capabilities within the Irish Leaving Certificate education system.

The proposal shifts from traditional financial knowledge delivery to capability development, equipping students to navigate complex financial signals and uncertainty.

II. Target Profile Analysis

Role & Leadership

- Minister for Education & Youth, Ireland
 - Leading: Curriculum reform (via NCCA) and the “National Conversation on Education” (system redesign)
-

Core Philosophy & Drivers

- Belief that education must prepare students “**for life ahead**” with emphasis on relevance, inclusion, and real-world readiness.
- Driven by **Legacy impact**, **Pragmatism** (system integration), and **Inclusivity + scale**.

Pain Points & Objectives

- Current education remains too theoretical; difficulty implementing practical programs at scale.
- Objectives: Move from **theoretical learning** → **applied capability** and create system-level transformation.

III. Proposal and Rationale: Financial Decision Capability

The Opportunity

The initiative addresses the gap in decision-making capability under real-world conditions for Leaving Certificate students. It focuses on the interpretation of financial signals and confidence in complex environments rather than simple investment knowledge.

Core Components

- Simulated real-world financial decision environments.
- Portfolio-based learning without capital risk.
- Structured evaluation and a national-level performance framework.

IV. Strategic Alignment & Recommendation

Alignment with Current Direction

- Policy alignment to prepare students “for life ahead.”
- System-level framing that integrates without curriculum disruption.
- Non-commercial tone involving credible external partners.

Recommendation

It is recommended to proceed with a pilot framework to demonstrate the pathway to scale. The immediate next step is to schedule a discussion to explore alignment with current Department of Education priorities.

FNOMO – EDUCATION POLICY PROPOSAL

FNOMO / FINTOMA TECHNOLOGY LIMITED

Financial Decision Capability Initiative for Leaving Certificate Students (Ireland)

1. CONTEXT

Ireland is currently undergoing a significant transformation in its education system.

The **National Conversation on Education** has been launched as a *“once-in-a-generation opportunity to shape the future of education”*

The core direction emerging from this initiative is clear:

- Move from **knowledge-based learning** → **real-world capability**
 - Prepare students for **life beyond school**
 - Enable students to navigate **complex, evolving environments (including AI-driven change)**
-

2. THE GAP

While financial literacy is being addressed at a foundational level, the current system does not fully address:

- Decision-making under uncertainty
- Interpretation of real-world financial signals
- Behavioural aspects of financial choices

Students today:

- have access to information
 - but lack **structured frameworks to make decisions**
-

3. THE OPPORTUNITY

Introduce a structured system that develops:

Financial Decision Capability (not just financial knowledge)

4. PROPOSED INITIATIVE

6-Month Structured Program for Leaving Certificate Students

Core Components

- Simulated real-world financial environments
 - Portfolio creation (no real capital risk)
 - Ongoing performance tracking
 - Decision evaluation framework
 - National-level participation structure
-

Engagement Layer

- Live decision-based simulation
 - Peer benchmarking
 - Performance-based recognition
-

Outcome Layer

- Enhanced confidence
- Improved decision clarity

- Real-world financial exposure
-

5. WHY THIS MATTERS (POLICY ALIGNMENT)

This initiative directly supports Ireland's education priorities:

This initiative does not introduce new curriculum content, but strengthens how students engage with existing knowledge in real-world decision contexts.

✓ Aligns with system transformation goals

- Supports shift toward **capability-based learning**
-

✓ Addresses real-world readiness

- Prepares students for **complex decision environments**
-

✓ Complements existing curriculum

- Does not require structural overhaul
 - Can integrate alongside existing frameworks
-

✓ Scalable at national level

- Designed for **institutional adoption**, not isolated programs
-

6. POSITIONING (CRITICAL)

This initiative is NOT:

- an investing program

- a financial advisory system
 - a commercial training model
-

This IS:

A structured decision capability layer within education

7. STRATEGIC VALUE TO IRELAND

- Builds financially aware and confident young population
 - Enhances long-term economic participation quality
 - Positions Ireland as a leader in **applied financial education**
 - Supports future workforce readiness
-

8. IMPLEMENTATION APPROACH

Phase 1

structured pilot pathway designed for scalable integration across the education system

Phase 2

Framework refinement

Phase 3

Scaled adoption across the system

9. OBJECTIVE

To explore:

- Alignment with current education priorities
 - Feasibility of pilot integration
 - Long-term scalability within the Irish education system
-

10. MINISTER EMAIL

Subject: Advancing real-world decision capability within Leaving Certificate education

Dear Minister,

I have been following the National Conversation on Education and your work in shaping a more relevant and future-ready system.

A consistent theme emerging from this is the need to move beyond knowledge delivery and toward **real-world capability development**.

In that context, I wanted to share a proposal that aligns closely with this direction.

While financial literacy is being addressed, there remains a gap in **decision-making capability under real-world conditions**, particularly at the Leaving Certificate stage.

We are proposing a structured initiative focused on developing this capability through simulated environments, portfolio-based learning, and structured evaluation over time.

This is not about introducing investing as a subject, but about equipping students with decision-making frameworks that extend beyond finance into broader life readiness.

The initiative is designed to complement existing curriculum structures and align with Ireland's broader education priorities.

I would value the opportunity to present this in more detail and explore whether it could align with current initiatives or pilot frameworks being considered.

Would it be possible to schedule a short discussion at your convenience?

Warm regards,

Strategy & Partnerships
Fnomo / Fintoma Technology Limited
www.fnomo.com

Ireland Core Decision Network

ROLE / POSITION	NAME	ORGANIZATION / NOTES	EMAIL	PROFESSIONAL PROFILE
Minister for Education & Youth	Hildegarde Naughton	Leads Department of Education & Youth / TOP ENTRY	hildegarde.naughton@oireachtas.ie	LinkedIn Profile
Secretary General	Bernie McNally	Department of Education & Youth / MOST IMPORTANT INTERNAL POWER / Actual operational decision authority	Official Department of Education contact channels	LinkedIn Profile
Chairperson (NCCA)	Seán Ó Foghlú	National Council for Curriculum & Assessment (NCCA) / REAL APPROVAL BODY	NCCA official contact (info@ncca.ie)	LinkedIn Profile
Vice Chair (NCCA)	Raymond McHugh	National Council for Curriculum & Assessment (NCCA)	NCCA official contact (info@ncca.ie)	LinkedIn Profile
General Contact	N/A	National Council for Curriculum & Assessment (NCCA) / Proposals are evaluated here. Website: https://ncca.ie	info@ncca.ie	LinkedIn Profile
Chair, Convention on Education	Professor Anne Looney	NATIONAL REFORM PLATFORM / Government's "once-in-a-generation reform channel"	Official Department of Education contact channels	LinkedIn Profile
Minister of State (Education)	Michael Moynihan	SECONDARY GOVERNMENT LAYER / Easier access, influences approvals	michael.moynihan@oireachtas.ie	LinkedIn Profile

Minister for Further & Higher Education	James Lawless	OPTIONAL BUT STRATEGIC / Drives global collaboration & partnerships	Official Department of Further & Higher Education contact channels	LinkedIn Profile
---	---------------	--	--	----------------------------------

HOW THE SYSTEM ACTUALLY WORKS

From government structure:

- Minister = **vision + approval**
- Advisors = **filter + evaluation**
- Department = **execution + validation**

And importantly:

👉 The Minister has **opened the system to external inputs** through the “National Conversation on Education” — inviting stakeholders and proposals

CORRECT APPROACH (VERY CLEAR)

We use:

1 CORE NARRATIVE → 3 DIFFERENT ANGLES

STRUCTURE YOU FOLLOW

1. MINISTER EMAIL

Focus:

- Vision
- System transformation
- National impact

👉 Tone:

Strategic + high-level

2. ADVISOR EMAIL (MOST IMPORTANT)

Focus:

- Feasibility
- alignment
- policy fit

👉 Tone:

Analytical + structured

3. DEPARTMENT EMAIL

Focus:

- implementation
- pilot
- operational details

👉 Tone:

practical + execution

EMAIL 2 — MINISTER'S OFFICE / ADVISORS

Subject: Supporting the National Conversation on Education — Structured proposal for Leaving Certificate

Dear [Advisor Name],

I am writing in the context of the National Conversation on Education currently underway and the department's efforts to gather structured inputs that can inform long-term system development.

This initiative does not introduce new curriculum content, but strengthens how students engage with existing knowledge in real-world decision contexts.

We have developed a proposal focused specifically on a gap that sits between financial literacy and real-world capability — particularly at the Leaving Certificate stage.

The initiative is designed as a structured, non-disruptive layer that can:

- integrate alongside existing curriculum
- develop decision-making capability under real-world conditions
- operate within a controlled, simulation-based environment

Importantly, the approach is not positioned as an additional subject, but as a framework that strengthens broader student readiness and aligns with current policy direction.

I would value the opportunity to share a short structured overview and understand how such an initiative might fit within current evaluation or pilot frameworks being considered.

Would it be possible to connect briefly or be directed to the appropriate team within the department to discuss a structured pilot pathway designed for scalable integration across the national education system?

Strategy & Partnerships

Fnomo / Fintoma Technology Limited

www.fnomo.com

WHY THIS WORKS

- references official process
- respects hierarchy
- asks for direction, not approval

EMAIL 3 — DEPARTMENT / NCCA / IMPLEMENTATION TEAM

Subject: Proposal for pilot integration — Leaving Certificate financial decision capability framework

Dear [Team/Official],

I am reaching out following the ongoing work within the Department of Education and associated bodies to strengthen curriculum relevance and real-world preparedness for students.

We have developed a structured initiative designed to support Leaving Certificate students in building decision-making capability within a simulated financial environment.

The framework is designed to:

- operate without disruption to existing curriculum
- provide measurable student outcomes
- be implemented as a pilot across selected institutions

The focus is not on financial instruction alone, but on developing decision frameworks that are transferable across multiple domains.

We would appreciate the opportunity to share a brief outline and understand the appropriate process for evaluating such initiatives within the current system.

Warm regards,

i

WHY THIS WORKS

- speaks their language
- focuses on implementation
- removes friction

We do this:

1. Send Minister's email
 2. Same day / next day → send Advisor email
 3. 1–2 days later → send Department email
-

What happens:

- Minister sees strategic alignment
 - Advisor sees structured thinking
 - Department sees executable model
-

👉 This creates:

multi-angle pressure + credibility

POSITIONING PRINCIPLE

We are not approaching this as:

- a program
 - a product
 - a training initiative
-

We are positioning this as:

A structured capability layer aligned with the evolving direction of Ireland's education system